

Lifelong Opportunity Guide 67 — Cook and Culinary Specialist

Version: 2.0 controlled working master

Language: English

Occupation benchmark: O*NET-SOC 35-2014.00 — Cooks, Restaurant

Canada comparison: NOC 63200 — Cooks

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What this career is

A cook or culinary specialist prepares, seasons, cooks, portions, and presents food in restaurants, hotels, cafeterias, hospitals, schools, catering operations, camps, commissaries, and similar settings. The work can include mise en place, following recipes, checking freshness, rotating stock, monitoring temperatures, cleaning and sanitizing work areas, using commercial kitchen equipment, receiving supplies within delegated authority, and coordinating routine kitchen tasks.

The title **culinary specialist** is not standardized. It may describe a line cook, prep cook, banquet cook, production cook, institutional cook, or another food-preparation role. It does not automatically mean chef, head cook, kitchen manager, food service manager, dietitian, nutritionist, or another higher-authority or regulated role.

This guide uses **O*NET-SOC 35-2014.00 — Cooks, Restaurant** as the primary U.S. occupational benchmark while keeping broader cook pathways and employer-specific titles clearly distinguished.

Why this role can be an opportunity

Cooking can provide an accessible entry point into hospitality and food service because many employers value practical skill, reliability, food-safety discipline, speed, teamwork, and consistency as much as formal education. People often begin in food preparation, dishwashing, counter service, or entry-level cook roles and progress through cross-training and demonstrated competence.

The field can suit people who enjoy hands-on work, visible results, repetition with room for craftsmanship, teamwork, and learning through practice. Experience can transfer into catering, institutional kitchens, hotels, production kitchens, restaurant operations, culinary training, or supervisory roles.

The work can also be demanding. Cooks may stand for long periods, work around heat, steam, sharp tools, hot oil, heavy containers, slippery floors, noise, time pressure, nights, weekends, holidays, and changing schedules.

Typical responsibilities

A cook or culinary specialist may:

- review prep lists, recipes, and production needs;
- gather and measure ingredients;
- wash, cut, trim, portion, season, and prepare foods;
- operate approved ovens, grills, broilers, fryers, steam equipment, mixers, slicers, and other tools after training;
- cook foods to required standards and monitor time and temperature controls;
- portion and plate food consistently;
- check freshness, date labels, and stock rotation;
- receive or store supplies within delegated authority;
- maintain clean and sanitary work areas;
- follow procedures for allergen communication and cross-contact prevention;
- document temperatures, waste, shortages, or incidents when required;
- coordinate routine work with other kitchen and service staff;
- report equipment, food-safety, staffing, or maintenance problems to the designated supervisor.

Authority boundaries

Do not assume that a cook or culinary specialist may independently:

- diagnose allergies or medical conditions;
- design therapeutic diets without qualified clinical authority;
- declare food safe when required controls have not been met;
- override employer or health-department food-safety requirements;
- hire, fire, suspend, or formally discipline employees;
- sign supplier or service contracts;
- approve major purchases or capital spending;
- alter payroll or time records outside authorized procedures;
- access unrestricted employee, customer, payment, or business information;
- represent the employer to regulators unless formally designated;
- conceal injuries, food-safety incidents, harassment, theft, or other reportable events.

When authority is unclear, escalate to the designated supervisor or manager.

Work environment and safety

Cooking work commonly involves hot surfaces, steam, hot oil, knives, slicers, mixers, ovens, lifting, repetitive motion, slippery floors, crowded work areas, and urgent service demands.

Follow employer training and procedures for:

- burns and scald prevention;
- knife and slicer safety;
- machine guards and lockout procedures where applicable;
- safe lifting and carrying;
- spill response and nonslip footwear;
- fire prevention and emergency response;
- personal protective equipment;
- chemical handling and sanitation products;
- reporting injuries, near misses, equipment defects, and unsafe conditions.

Never bypass a food-safety or worker-safety control to increase speed or production.

Skills employers value

Kitchen skills

- knife handling after training;
- mise en place;
- recipe reading;
- measuring and weighing;
- grilling, roasting, baking, frying, steaming, sautéing, and other applicable methods;
- portion control;
- food presentation;
- temperature monitoring;
- stock rotation;
- cleaning and sanitizing.

Work habits

- reliability and punctuality;
- attention to detail;
- ability to work under pressure;
- teamwork;

- clean work habits;
- ability to follow standardized procedures;
- willingness to learn multiple stations;
- calm communication during busy periods.

Business awareness

- waste reduction;
- inventory awareness;
- yield and portion consistency;
- basic cost awareness;
- production planning;
- understanding how food quality and service speed affect customer experience.

Education and entry pathways — United States

Many cook roles can be entered with a high school education or less, depending on the employer, followed by on-the-job training. Formal culinary school is not universally required.

A practical low-cost progression can be:

1. gain entry-level food-service experience;
2. learn hygiene, sanitation, food handling, and safe equipment use;
3. become dependable at one station;
4. cross-train on additional stations;
5. learn inventory, prep planning, and portion control;
6. complete employer-required food-safety training;
7. pursue apprenticeship, community-college, technical, or employer-supported culinary training only when it improves access to the next role.

O*NET lists example Registered Apprenticeship titles including **Chef de Partie (Cook Hotel & Restaurant)**, **Cook, Cook (Hotel & Restaurant)**, and **Production Cook**. Availability is local and employer-dependent; apprenticeship is not a universal requirement.

Food-safety certification and jurisdiction checks

The FDA publishes the **2022 Food Code**, with a 2024 supplement, as a model for retail and food-service safety. It is not one nationwide restaurant law. State, local, tribal, territorial, and other authorities decide how provisions are adopted and enforced.

Before paying for a food-handler, food-protection-manager, allergen, or other course or exam, verify:

- the actual requirement of the controlling health authority;
- which credentials the employer accepts;
- whether the role requires the credential personally;
- whether the employer pays for training or exam fees;
- renewal requirements;
- whether an employer-specific course is sufficient for the assigned duties.

Food safety and allergen awareness

Follow applicable rules and employer procedures for:

- handwashing and hygiene;
- employee illness reporting;
- receiving and storage;
- time and temperature control;
- cross-contamination prevention;
- cleaning and sanitizing;
- labeling and stock rotation;
- allergen communication and cross-contact controls;
- pest control;
- waste handling;
- incident escalation.

Do not diagnose allergies or make medical claims. Use approved ingredient, recipe, and preparation information and escalate uncertainty rather than guessing.

Canada pathway

The closest Canadian benchmark is **NOC 63200 — Cooks**. Job Bank describes cooks as preparing and cooking a wide variety of foods in restaurants, hotels, hospitals, health-care institutions, central commissaries, educational institutions, ships, camps, and similar settings. Apprentices are included in the unit group.

Job Bank states that secondary school is usually required and that a three-year cook apprenticeship, a college or other cooking/food-safety program, or several years of commercial cooking experience may be required. Trade certification is available but voluntary across provinces and territories, and qualified cooks may pursue the Red Seal endorsement after the interprovincial examination.

Requirements vary by province, territory, employer, and establishment type. Verify the actual local pathway before paying for training.

Colombia pathway

SENA Betowa provides public pathways relevant to entry and progression.

COCINA — Técnico

Current SENA Betowa information lists **COCINA** as a titled (Titulada) **Técnico** program, in person, with a duration of **2,200 hours**. The program focuses on receiving and handling raw materials, food preparation, quality standards, and support for food-service operations under food-safety parameters.

Verify current intake, location, prerequisites, and selection requirements directly in Betowa.

COCINA BÁSICA NIVEL 1

SENA Betowa lists **COCINA BÁSICA NIVEL 1** as a complementary special course, in person, with a duration of **40 hours**. It can be a useful free-first or lower-cost entry option where available.

Completion does not guarantee employment, promotion, food-safety authorization, or chef status.

No national Colombia wage benchmark is claimed in this guide.

Latin America pathway

Culinary training differs widely across Latin America. Useful starting points include national vocational-training institutions, labor or education ministries, public tourism and hospitality institutes, employer academies, and OIT/Cinterfor-linked institutions.

Before enrolling, verify:

- provider recognition where relevant;
- total cost, including uniforms, knives, tools, exams, transportation, and ingredients;
- practical-stage or internship requirements;
- food-handler or health-document requirements;
- schedule compatibility with work;
- whether the credential is portable to another employer or region.

Free-first training strategy

Before paying for an expensive private culinary program, check whether the goal can be reached through:

- employer-paid onboarding or cross-training;
- paid food-safety training;

- community or technical programs;
- **CareerOneStop WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder** for eligible U.S. participants;
- local **American Job Centers**;
- **Apprenticeship.gov** for actual cook apprenticeship openings;
- SENA Betowa in Colombia;
- OIT/Cinterfor and national public training institutions elsewhere in Latin America.

Funding, admission, apprenticeship placement, reimbursement, certification, and employment are never guaranteed.

Compensation — United States

Official Restaurant Cooks benchmark

O*NET currently reports BLS **2025 wage data** for **Cooks, Restaurant (35-2014.00)**:

- median hourly wage: **USD \$17.98**;
- median annual wage: **USD \$37,390**;
- 25th percentile annual wage: **USD \$34,010**;
- 75th percentile annual wage: **USD \$44,620**.

O*NET reports approximately **1,460,200** restaurant cooks employed in 2024, projected growth of **7% or higher** over 2024-2034, and approximately **250,700 projected job openings** over that projection period.

Broader BLS Cooks comparison

The BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook reports a broader **Cooks** benchmark with median pay of **USD \$35,760/year (\$17.19/hour)**, about **2,805,100** jobs, projected growth of **5%**, and approximately **130,600 openings per year**.

The BLS group covers several cook specialties, so do not treat its broader figures as identical to the O*NET Restaurant Cooks benchmark.

Current non-government estimate

ZipRecruiter, August 4, 2026, reports average Cook pay of **USD \$33,340/year**, approximately **\$16.03/hour**, with a reported 25th-75th percentile range of **\$28,000-\$37,500**.

This is a non-government market estimate and should not be averaged with official O*NET/BLS statistics.

Compensation — Canada

Job Bank national wage data for **NOC 63200**, updated November 19, 2025 using the 2023–2024 Labour Force Survey reference period, reports:

- low: **CAD \$15.00/hour**;
- median: **CAD \$18.00/hour**;
- high: **CAD \$25.00/hour**.

Actual pay varies by province, establishment, schedule, experience, specialization, and employer.

Privacy and payment information

Kitchen and restaurant systems may contain customer, employee, payment, scheduling, ordering, delivery-platform, inventory, and business information. Use only the access needed for your job.

Good practices include:

- never sharing passwords or POS credentials;
- locking terminals when leaving them;
- avoiding personal devices for restricted business information unless approved;
- using approved channels for schedules and employee information;
- limiting printed reports and disposing of them securely;
- escalating suspected phishing, fraud, or account compromise.

Cybersecurity

Restaurants increasingly use cloud POS systems, online ordering, delivery platforms, digital inventory tools, payroll systems, supplier portals, Wi-Fi, and mobile devices.

Treat unexpected password-reset requests, invoices, QR codes, payment changes, vendor messages, payroll changes, or bank-account changes cautiously. Verify unusual requests through approved channels before acting.

Accessibility and inclusion

Support accessible service and a respectful workplace according to employer procedures and applicable law. Do not make assumptions about a customer or coworker's capabilities. Escalate accommodation questions through the designated manager or HR process when needed.

Responsible use of artificial intelligence

AI tools can help brainstorm practice recipes, training outlines, prep checklists, non-sensitive menu wording, study questions, or career plans.

Do **not** enter payment-card data, employee records, customer personal information, unpublished recipes, business data, incident reports, passwords, internal investigations, or other restricted information into a public AI system without organizational approval.

AI must not independently decide:

- whether food is safe to serve;
- whether an allergen is present;
- whether a customer or worker has a medical condition;
- whether a legal or regulatory requirement applies;
- whether an injury or food-safety incident can be ignored.

Human review is required for AI-assisted recipes, menus, training materials, schedules, labels, customer communications, and operational decisions.

A 12-week start plan

Weeks 1-2 — Learn the operation

- Learn sanitation, emergency, and reporting procedures.
- Review kitchen layout, stations, storage, and equipment.
- Learn authority boundaries and escalation routes.

Weeks 3-4 — Build station competence

- Practice mise en place and recipe execution.
- Learn temperature checks, labeling, and stock rotation.
- Improve cleaning and closing routines.

Weeks 5-6 — Increase consistency

- Focus on portion control and repeatable quality.
- Practice communication during busy periods.
- Learn waste and shortage reporting.

Weeks 7-8 — Cross-train

- Learn a second station or production function.
- Practice receiving or inventory tasks within authority.
- Learn how prep planning supports service flow.

Weeks 9-10 — Build evidence

- Document training completed.
- Record improvements in speed, waste, consistency, organization, or safety without disclosing confidential information.

Weeks 11-12 — Prepare for advancement

- Ask what distinguishes your current role from lead cook, chef de partie, or supervisor roles.
- Identify missing skills or credentials.
- Request feedback and apply for appropriate next-step opportunities.

Experience-building ideas

Useful experience can come from:

- mastering a station;
- training a new employee on a routine task;
- improving a prep or closing checklist;
- reducing waste or inventory errors;
- supporting a food-safety inspection;
- participating in a menu rollout;
- improving labeling or stock rotation;
- helping implement a new POS, inventory, or ordering process.

Describe the action and result without revealing employer-confidential information.

Career progression

Possible pathways include:

- food preparation worker or kitchen helper;
- prep cook;
- line cook;
- restaurant cook;
- production or institutional cook;
- lead cook or chef de partie;
- sous chef;
- chef or head cook;
- kitchen supervisor or food-service management roles where qualifications and authority support the move.

Progression is not automatic and titles vary widely by employer.

Before accepting a job or training program

Verify:

- hourly or salaried status;
- expected weekly hours and overtime rules;
- nights, weekends, holidays, and split-shift expectations;

- food-safety credential requirements;
- whether training and exam costs are employer-paid;
- physical requirements;
- tool, uniform, knife, or footwear requirements;
- whether training time is paid;
- apprenticeship or promotion criteria;
- access to scheduling, POS, payment, or inventory systems;
- accommodation process;
- total school or program cost and whether the credential improves access to the target job.

Controlled source list

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Important notice

This guide provides general educational and career-planning information. It does not guarantee employment, earnings, admission, funding, certification, licensing, promotion, apprenticeship placement, or any other result. Requirements vary by jurisdiction, employer, establishment type, and time. Always verify current requirements with the relevant employer and government authority.

Assurance boundary

This Version 2 working master was developed through internal machine-assisted research and editorial review. It is not independent human certification, professional culinary certification, professional food-safety

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